

# Regulating influencer marketing in the European Union

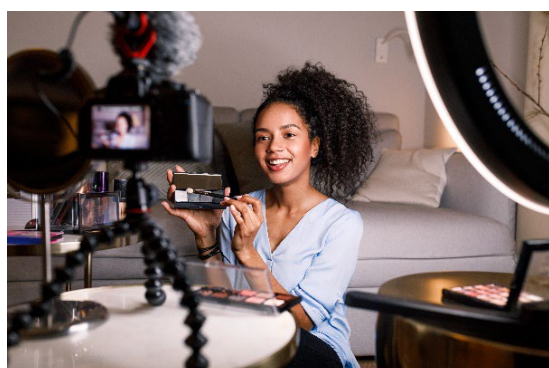
## SUMMARY

Influencer marketing has become a significant part of the digital economy. Influencers allow brands to reach highly targeted audiences, and their endorsements are often perceived as more authentic than direct advertising. Some consumer groups – such as younger consumers and those with lower financial literacy, lower income, or consumers who follow trends closely – are particularly receptive to this type of marketing.

The fast growth of this sector has exposed several problematic practices and regulatory challenges in the EU. Many influencers do not clearly disclose the commercial intent behind their posts, while others manipulate visibility by buying fake followers, likes or plays to inflate their perceived influence and to make more profit. Additional concerns include reinforcing unrealistic beauty standards, promoting harmful or illegal products, accelerating the spread of false and misleading claims, and exploiting kidfluencers for financial gain.

At EU level, laws relevant to influencer marketing exist but are fragmented across consumer protection, digital and audiovisual media regulation. Hidden advertising and misleading commercial practices are already prohibited, yet the responsibilities of different actors in the influencer marketing value chain are not always clear. Some EU Member States, such as France and Spain, have complemented these EU laws with national legislation, and many have issued guidance to help influencers and companies understand their legal obligations.

The European Commission has signalled its intention to address misleading influencer marketing practices in the forthcoming digital fairness act. The European Parliament and Council will play a central role in shaping this legislation once the proposal is published.



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## Introduction

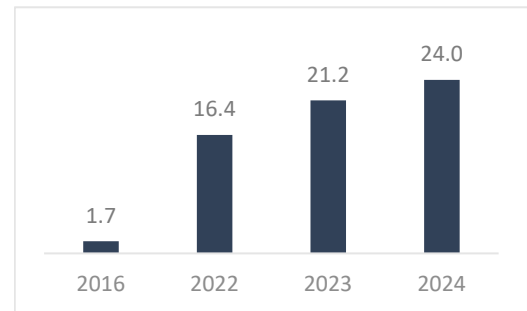
Influencer marketing has grown significantly in recent years, becoming a central form of online advertising and an increasingly important segment of the digital economy. The Influencer Marketing Hub's 2024 [report](#) estimates the global influencer market will reach US\$24 billion (€20.65 billion) in 2024 (see Figure 1).

Influencer marketing allows brands to reach highly targeted audiences through individuals whose content appeals to specific interests or demographics. Because [influencers](#) are often perceived as ordinary users rather than professional advertisers, their endorsement of brands is considered more authentic than direct advertising by brands. This perceived authenticity is a core commercial asset and one reason why businesses allocate a growing share of their marketing budget to influencer partnerships. In a survey by Influencer Marketing Hub, over 85 % of brands and PR agencies globally said they plan to use influencer marketing. Some 25 % intend to spend more than 40 % of their marketing budget on influencers. Most prefer to use nano- and micro-influencers, who charge lower fees than macro- and mega-influencers.<sup>1</sup> The most common social media platform used by brands to advertise via influencers was TikTok, followed by Instagram, YouTube and Facebook.

[Younger consumer groups](#) (up to 30 years old) are particularly receptive to influencer marketing, and more likely to purchase products recommended by influencers. A recent [survey](#) by the Digital Marketing Institute finds that 45 % of European [Generation Z](#) consumers are more inclined to buy fashion items worn by influencers than by traditional celebrities or peers. This may be due not only to higher social media use by younger users but also to lower advertising literacy skills at very early ages.

Another vulnerable group consists of consumers with lower financial literacy, lower income, as well as consumers who closely follow trends. They may be more susceptible to persuasive influencer techniques; social

Figure 1 – Global influencer marketing market size, in billion US dollars



Source: [The State of Influencer Marketing 2024](#).

### Who are influencers?

There is no uniform definition of influencers, although some EU countries, as well as academics, have defined them. For example, in 2022, Michaelsen *et al* described an influencer as 'a content creator with a commercial intent, who builds trust and authenticity-based relations with their audience (mainly on social media platforms) and engages online with commercial actors through different business models for monetisation purposes'. In the Unfair Commercial Practices Directive guidelines, the European Commission also included virtual entities in its definition of an influencer, saying that 'an influencer is generally described as a natural person or virtual entity who has a greater than average reach in a relevant platform'.

Influencers may advertise products and services in exchange for monetary or other type of remuneration (such as free products and services) or promote their own products and services. Some definitions also include influencers without a commercial intent.

Often, the term '(content) creator' is used instead of 'influencer'. This choice of words reflects the desire to highlight the creativity aspect, rather than the influence on audiences' attitudes and actions.

Sources: [The impact of influencers on advertising and consumer protection in the Single Market](#), IMCO study, 2022; Kozinets *et al* [Influencers and Creators: Business, Culture and Practice](#), 2023.

media makes consumption very easy. Sometimes products can be bought with a simple click from an app or with payment methods such as 'buy-now-pay-later', which may entrap consumers in debt.

## Problematic influencer marketing practices

The rapid expansion of influencer marketing has brought to light several problematic practices and regulatory challenges in the EU. In 2024, the [European Commission](#) and the national consumer protection authorities of 22 Member States, Norway and Iceland examined posts by 576 influencers on TikTok, Instagram, YouTube, Facebook, X, Snapchat and Twitch. The sweep revealed widespread non-compliance with transparency and consumer-protection rules.

### Failing to sufficiently disclose commercial intent

A first recurrent problem is the lack of clear disclosure of commercial relationships between brands and influencers. The 2024 EU sweep found that 97 % of the reviewed influencers posted commercial content, but only about 20 % systematically indicated that their posts were advertisements. Some 38 % failed to use platform-provided labels such as 'paid partnership', opting instead for vague terms such as 'collaboration' or 'thanks to the brand'. Only 36 % were registered as traders at the national level, and 30 % failed to provide any company details on their posts.

Commercial intent can also exist without written contracts – for example, when influencers receive free products, trips or other advantages. If such posts are not explicitly disclosed as advertising, consumers may incorrectly assume that influencers' recommendations are personal and unbiased.

One driver of under-disclosure is the belief among influencers that transparency reduces engagement (fewer likes, comments and shares), and thus decreases their market value. However, some [studies](#) suggest that proper disclosure does not significantly affect engagement. The mere fact that a post is advertising (disclosed or not) drives the fall-off. Yet, other [research](#) finds measurable drops in engagement after the implementation of disclosure rules. The evidence is therefore mixed.

Online platforms also contribute to opacity. As Annabell, Bishop and Goanta argue in their 2025 [study](#) of TikTok, the platform strategically blurs the boundary between ordinary users and commercial actors by referring to all users as 'creators', while still controlling who can monetise their content and what content is more visible.

### Pretending to have brand deals and inflating follower counts

At the opposite end of the spectrum, emerging influencers sometimes pretend to have brand partnerships to attract real contracts later. In addition, some influencers deliberately buy fake followers, likes or plays to inflate their perceived influence and increase profit, or operate networks of fake accounts. As revealed in a 2023 [study](#) by Nevado-Catalán *et al*, influencers can purchase 'fake engagement services by selecting features such as the quality of the service, the speed of delivery, the country of origin, and even personal attributes of the fake account (e.g., gender)' in a vast underground market. These practices deceive both consumers as well as brands. A 2023 [study](#) by Zhou *et al* suggests that even when consumers suspect fake followers, perceived influence still increases.

## Reinforcing unrealistic beauty standards

[Influencers](#) frequently use filters, poses and lighting to present themselves in ways that emphasise beauty and attractiveness. This leads to the posting of highly curated, edited images and videos where influencers are depicted as looking flawless, skinny or hyper-muscular, with uniform, white teeth, reflecting unrealistic and largely unattainable beauty standards. The spread of such images and videos can lead to upward social comparison, diminished self-esteem and may encourage unhealthy habits such as extreme dieting or recourse to harmful cosmetic procedures. For example, in 2022, [Pedalino and Camerini](#) found that browsing Instagram is associated with lower levels of body appreciation. A 2025 [study](#) by Peng and Hakimzadeh reveals that frequently browsing 'beauty influencer content often leads to increased self-objectification, body dissatisfaction, pressure to conform, and homogenized beauty standards'. Another [study](#) in 2024 suggests that following Instagram beauty and fit-influencers is associated not only with lower body satisfaction but also with elevated eating-disorder symptoms.

However, a counter-trend of influencers presenting themselves more [authentically](#) has emerged in recent years, with #NoFilter tags or promoting body acceptance and self-compassion. As evidenced in the study by Peng and Hakimzadeh, such content tends to provide followers 'emotional relief and a sense of reassurance, helping them to improve body satisfaction and mood'.

## Advertising harmful or illegal products

Some influencers exploit consumer trust to promote harmful products and normalise unhealthy consumption such as drinks and food with high sugar content or alcoholic beverages, by showing these products in a positive light. In the 2024 EU sweep, one in five influencers screened by the European Commission and national consumer protection authorities promoted unhealthy or hazardous activities, such as junk food, alcoholic beverages, medical or aesthetic treatments, gambling, or financial services such as crypto trading. This exposure to harmful products can have adverse health effects, particularly when involving minors or other vulnerable consumers.

Some influencers promote counterfeit products, helping to proliferate illegal activities and exposing followers to safety risks<sup>2</sup> and legal problems. According to a 2023 [study](#) by Sheperd *et al*, promoting counterfeit products through influencers significantly influences consumers' purchase decisions. Based on two surveys in the United Kingdom, the study estimates that '22 % of consumers aged 16–60 years and active on social media purchase counterfeits because the illicit goods were recommended by influencers'. In addition to undermining consumer trust, these practices can erode lawful sales and damage the reputation of luxury businesses. Moreover, counterfeit products are often produced in factories that offer low salaries and unsafe working conditions.

## Accelerating the spread of false and misleading claims

Because influencers cultivate close, trust-based relationships with their followers, they often act as informal opinion leaders without necessarily being better-informed. When influencers share content without verification, they can accelerate the spread of false and misleading claims. A 2024 UNESCO [survey](#) on content creators from 45 countries reports that 63 % of creators admit they do not verify information before sharing. Many of those who do attempt to verify rely on questionable metrics of credibility, such as the number of likes and views of the original post or their personal experience with the content.

## Exploiting child influencers

Children can be exploited in influencer marketing not only as an audience but also as content creators, known as 'kidfluencers'. While some kidfluencers share their lives on social media independently, in many cases parents retain substantial control over the content, commercial partnerships and earnings. A 2024 [study](#) by Van den Abeele *et al* of kidfluencers aged 7–12 and their parents living in the Netherlands, the UK or Belgium found that kidfluencer profiles often do not authentically represent the children's true selves, but rather how parents wish to present their children. Another [study](#) by Clark and Jno-Charles in 2025 describes kidfluencing as a new form of child labour, in which child's play is monetised as work. The study identifies several risks to children's rights, such as violations of privacy, economic exploitation and emotional and psychological harm. Although kidfluencers may benefit from earnings through family's improved financial situation, their earnings are often not retained in a bank account in the child's name, accessible to the child at their adulthood.

## Current EU legislation

Influencer marketing is not covered by a dedicated EU law, but rather falls under a set of horizontal regulation, including consumer-protection law, the Audiovisual Media Services Directive, the Digital Services Act and the Digital Markets Act. These laws target certain problematic practices such as hidden advertising and misleading commercial practices. Some examples are given below.

### Unfair Commercial Practices Directive

One of the most relevant EU laws is the [Unfair Commercial Practices Directive](#) (UCPD). Although the directive does not regulate influencers directly, it does address practices such as hidden advertising. Article 7(2) of the UCPD regards a failure to disclose the commercial intent of a trader as a misleading omission. Article 8 prohibits aggressive commercial practices such as undue influence. Annex I (point 11) prohibit practices that do not make it clear that a trader has paid for the promotion of a product in editorial content in the media. Point 22 prohibits falsely representing oneself as a consumer. Point 28 prohibits directly exhorting children to buy advertised products or persuade their parents or other adults to buy advertised products for them.

According to the European Commission [guidance](#), the UCPD applies whenever an influencer receives any form of consideration for the endorsement of the product or service such as monetary payment, a percentage from affiliate links, free products or trips. The presence of a contract and monetary payment is not necessary to trigger the application of these rules. Disclosures must be visible and should not require consumers to take additional steps such as clicking on 'read more'. For example, merely tagging a brand's name is not sufficient.

### e-Commerce Directive

The [e-Commerce Directive](#) states that any commercial information must be clearly identifiable as such (Article 6). In addition, the directive helps to understand what is meant by 'commercial information': 'any form of communication designed to promote, directly or indirectly, the goods, services or image of a company, organisation or person pursuing a commercial, industrial or craft activity or exercising a regulated profession'.

## Audiovisual Media Services Directive

Another law that applies to influencers on video-sharing platforms such as YouTube or TikTok is the [Audiovisual Media Services Directive](#) (AVSMD), although the directive itself does not specifically mention influencers. Article 9 of the AVSMD requires that audiovisual commercial communications are readily recognisable as such. These communications should not use subliminal techniques, nor encourage unhealthy or unsafe habits. The AVSMD pays special attention to the protection of minors, by prohibiting all audiovisual commercial communications that may cause physical, mental or moral detriment to minors. For example, audiovisual commercial communications advertising alcoholic beverages should not target minors, nor encourage the immoderate consumption of such beverages.

## Digital Services Act

The [Digital Services Act](#) (DSA) regulates influencer marketing indirectly, but only on online platforms and not on other websites such as blogs. For example, Article 26 of the DSA obliges online platforms to provide their users (influencers included) with functionalities to declare commercial communications, ensuring users can clearly identify advertising in real time. Article 28 of the DSA prohibits targeting advertising at minors on online platforms. Article 30 obliges online platforms to collect certain identity information from influencers acting as traders. When an online platform learns that a trader-influencer offers an illegal product or service to consumers through its services, it must inform the consumers affected and provide redress information. [Very large search engines or very large online platforms](#), such as Instagram, Facebook, Snapchat and TikTok, face stricter duties to assess systemic risks, including undisclosed advertising and illegal content.

In May 2025, the European Commission preliminarily found that [TikTok](#) fails to provide the necessary information about the content of advertisements, who paid for them and who is targeted. In October 2025, the Commission reached a preliminary view that [Meta](#) failed to provide users with simple mechanisms to report illegal content or contest content moderation decisions.

## Digital Markets Act

Although the [Digital Markets Act](#) (DMA) does not directly target influencer marketing, it shapes the online environment in which influencer marketing takes place. It regulates the behaviour of online platforms acting as gatekeepers between business users and their customers. The DMA prohibits, for example, gatekeepers from combining personal data across their services for targeted advertising. As mentioned by [Kolsquare](#), this requirement may lead companies and brands to invest more in influencer marketing, as influencers allow them to reach more targeted audiences.

## Influencer Legal Hub

To help influencers, brands, and agencies navigate the evolving landscape of influencer marketing regulation in Europe, the European Commission has launched an [Influencer Legal Hub](#). The hub provides a collection of material including training videos, research reports, links to national guidelines, case studies from the European Court of Justice, and overviews of relevant EU laws. The information in the Influencer Legal Hub reflects the [five principles on social media marketing disclosures](#) adopted by the Consumer Protection Cooperation Network:

- 1 Influencers should clearly indicate in the language of the post the commercial nature of the content.
- 2 Disclosure should be prominent and clearly distinguished from other content.
- 3 Disclosure should appear where consumers will immediately see it.
- 4 Traders should also consider available research on how consumers perceive specific disclosures.
- 5 When content is likely to be seen by children, disclosures should be adapted to their level of understanding.

## National rules

### France

As the first EU Member State to adopt a dedicated law on influencers, France adopted [law n° 2023-451](#) in June 2023, aimed at regulating commercial influence and combating abuse by influencers on social networks who target French audiences. The law has since been amended several times. It<sup>3</sup> requires that sponsored or paid posts are clearly, legibly and understandably disclosed as commercial content. If photos or videos are edited to alter the physical appearance of a person (body or face), a disclaimer '*images retouchées*' ('retouched images') must be added. If the photo or video is AI-generated, a disclaimer '*images virtuelles*' ('virtual images') is required.

The law also sets out rules for contractual obligations for influencer partnerships and bans certain practices such as promoting aesthetic medical procedures, pseudo-therapeutic practices claiming to replace medical treatments, nicotine-containing products, certain exotic or wild animals, some financial services, sports betting advice and gambling. Foreign influencers addressing French audiences must appoint an EU-based legal representative and hold civil liability insurance.

### Spain

Spain adopted [royal decree 444/2024](#) on 30 April 2024, which applies to high-profile influencers generating at least €300 000 in annual revenue, or with more than one million followers and posting at least 24 videos in the previous calendar year. The royal decree brings such influencers under the Spanish audiovisual communications regime by treating them as 'users of special relevance' and aligning their obligations with other audiovisual media service providers. Qualifying influencers must register with the Spanish national registry of audiovisual communication, video-sharing platforms and aggregator service providers. Once registered, they must comply with various EU and Spanish rules, including clear identification of commercial communications and avoidance of inappropriate content targeting minors.

### Italy

The [Italian Communications Regulatory Authority](#) (AGCOM) adopted guidelines on 23 July 2025, together with a [code of conduct](#) for influencers operating in Italy who have at least 500 000 followers or more than one million monthly views. Although named 'a code of conduct', it is binding as it is adopted under ACCOM's regulatory power for commercial communications. The Italian code of conduct sets several obligations. Influencers must clearly mark paid collaborations using standard labels from the Istituto dell'Autodisciplina Pubblicitaria's [digital charter](#),<sup>4</sup> such as '*pubblicità*' ('advertising'), '*promosso da ... brand*' ('promoted by ...brand'), '*sponsorizzato da ... brand*'

('sponsored by ... brand') or 'adv/ad+ brand'. They should also disclose the use of filters and digital alterations. Content must not undermine human dignity or promote violence, hate, or discrimination of any kind. In addition, influencers should avoid content that could seriously harm the physical, psychological, or moral development of minors.

## The Netherlands

In the Netherlands, the [Social Media and Influencer Advertising Code](#) (last updated on 1 July 2022) sets detailed rules for influencers who are paid or receive any other benefits for advertising. The code details how the commercial content should be disclosed on various types of platforms: video-, photo/message sharing and podcast platforms, and streaming services. It mentions, for example, that if only a hashtag is used (e.g. #ad, #reclame, #advertentie), it should be immediately visible and may not be hidden among other hashtags or information. Simply mentioning the brand name is not sufficient to meet clear disclosure requirements. If the advertisement targets children, disclosure should also be understandable for children. The code specifically prohibits the use of fake followers and likes.

Mega- and macro-influencers (with at least 500 000 followers) must also comply with the [Dutch Media Act](#). They are required to join the Dutch Advertising Code Authority as well as to register with the Netherlands Institute for the Classification of Audio-visual Media. They must ensure full transparency concerning advertising, sponsorship and product placement, and not encourage the purchase of prohibited products and services.

## National guidelines

In addition to binding legal dispositions, numerous guidelines on influencer marketing exist. Usually, these guidelines are intended to help influencers and companies/brands understand their obligations. They give specific recommendations on how to disclose the advertising. Several such instruments have been published by bodies overseeing ethical standards in advertising or bodies promoting consumer protection.

## Belgium

For example, the Belgian Advertising Council published [guidelines](#) for influencer marketing in 2022 (last updated in August 2025). The guidelines give specific recommendations on how to disclose advertising and which labels to use (for example, 'advertisement' or 'publicity'), or not to use (for example abbreviations such as 'ad' or 'pub'). The guidelines encourage influencers to make the labels immediately visible to followers and to adapt the labels to the language of the target audience. The commercial nature of the content should also be understandable for children.

### Influencer training and certification

Some Member States' self-regulatory advertising bodies have developed training and certification programmes. For example, the French Autorité de la régulation professionnelle de la publicité (ARPP) has launched a responsible business influence certificate aimed at promoting ethical and responsible influencer marketing practices. It helps influencers to understand and comply with relevant rules on influencer marketing. Similarly, the European Advertising Standards Alliance (EASA) has developed a training and certification programme for influencers called adEthics.

Source: [ARPP](#) and [adethics](#).

## Finland

In Finland, the [Consumer Ombudsman](#) updated guidelines on labelling influencer marketing in social media in 2025, clarifying how commercial cooperation must be disclosed under the Finnish Consumer Protection Act. Influencers are encouraged to use labels such as 'advertisement with (company/brand)', 'commercial collaboration with (company/brand)', 'commercial cooperation (company/brand)', complemented by platform-provided labelling functions. In contrast, labels such as 'received (company/brand)', 'thank you (company/brand)' or 'product/service/ticket received (company/brand)' are deemed unclear, as they do not show whether the product or service was received in exchange for advertising. Disclosures should be visible from the start and during the entire duration of the commercial content. They should not be hidden behind 'read more'. Even without a formal agreement, influencers should label posts featuring products or services received for advertising purposes, while no disclosure is required for products or services they purchase themselves.

## Ireland

The Irish Competition and Competition Commission published [guidance](#) in 2023, which aims to help influencers to comply with consumer protection law and the Advertising Standards Authority for Ireland (ASAI) Code of Standards for Advertising and Marketing Communications. It states that if an influencer benefits from mentioning a brand on social media, the resulting content is commercial content, and this must be obvious to viewers. The term 'benefit' is defined broadly, including cases where influencers have requested a free product or service from the brand or where a brand has sent them a free product or service as a gift without any expectation that the influencer will post about it.

## Advisory committees

The European Economic and Social Committee (EESC) adopted an [opinion](#) on advertising through influencers and its impact on consumers on 13 July 2023 (rapporteur: Bernardo Hernández Bataller). It called for the prevention of minors' access to sensitive, harmful or age-inappropriate content such as alcohol and energy drinks, gambling and betting activities, pornography, tobacco and tobacco products, and aesthetic surgery. This content should be marked 'prohibited for children under 18'. Similarly to France, the EESC urges online platforms and influencers to use the term 'retouched image' for altered photos and the term 'virtual image' for AI-generated content.

## Stakeholders' views<sup>5</sup>

Stakeholders disagree on whether influencer marketing needs further EU regulation. Consumer protection organisations call for tighter rules, while online platforms and influencer representatives argue the additional regulation is unnecessary.

The European Consumer Organisation [BEUC](#) has repeatedly urged the EU to adopt binding rules on influencers. Already in 2023, it asked the EU to define 'influencer marketing' in law and to assume commercial intent whenever a post is made in exchange for any form of consideration. BEUC also calls for EU-wide, standardised advertisement labelling requirements and for a joint liability between influencers, their agencies and brands. It proposes bans on influencer marketing for unhealthy food, gambling and alcohol advertisements targeting minors, medical

products/procedures and high-risk financial products. Platforms should be required to set up reporting tools, forward complaints to the competent authorities, promptly remove hidden advertising or illegal content and apply proportionate and effective sanctions when rules are breached. BEUC made similar recommendations in its December 2025 [position paper](#), adding that '(p)ersons under the age of 15 should not be allowed to act as influencers or to appear in influencer marketing'.

In its response to the call for evidence on the proposed digital fairness act, the European Brands Association [AIM](#) – representing consumer goods manufacturers in the EU – calls for a clear EU definition of 'influencer' and shared liability across the advertising chain. Obligations should apply to all influencers targeting European consumers. AIM also wants better tools for consumers to flag unsafe or counterfeit products. In AIM's view, responsible marketing in categories such as food and alcohol is already effectively governed by self- and co-regulation.

The European Influencer Marketing Alliance ([EIMA](#)) – the federation of professional influencer marketing organisations across Europe – prefers practical guidance and stronger enforcement rather than new legislation. It welcomes the Influencer Legal Hub and encourages social media platforms to promote the hub to influencers.

[TikTok](#) opposes overlapping obligations and calls for greater awareness among influencers and brands of their existing obligations. It rejects inflexible, mandatory rules on how commercial content must be disclosed. TikTok proposes a centralised supervisory and enforcement authority that could launch investigations and coordinate action where influencer marketing rules are widely breached.

## Outlook

The [2024 fitness check](#) of EU consumer law on digital fairness confirmed that legal uncertainty persists, especially regarding the responsibilities of actors in the influencer-marketing value chain, such as the brands whose products and services influencers promote.

In its [2026 work programme](#), under the priority 'Protecting our democracy, upholding our values' the European Commission announced a legislative initiative for the fourth quarter of 2026 – the digital fairness act. The initiative is expected to address several online consumer protection challenges, including misleading influencer marketing practices, [dark patterns](#) that can unfairly influence consumer decisions, addictive design of digital products and unfair personalisation practices that take advantage of consumers' vulnerabilities. A [public consultation](#) on the initiative was open until 24 October 2025.

In its [resolution](#) of 8 May 2025 on the old challenges and new commercial practices in the internal market, the European Parliament welcomed the Commission's 2024 fitness check of EU consumer law and called on the Commission to address influencer advertising in the upcoming digital fairness act. In another [resolution](#) of 26 November 2025 on the protection of minors online, the Parliament calls on the Commission to prohibit 'platforms from monetising or otherwise providing financial or material incentives for kidfluencing'.

In its [conclusions](#) of 14 May 2024, the Council called on the European Commission and Member States to foster responsible influencer behaviour, support media and digital literacy among the influencers' audience and greater study of kidfluencers' situation and wellbeing.

These developments show growing momentum for an EU-level intervention to address misleading influencer marketing practices. However, the digital fairness act is emerging at a time when the European [Commission](#) and several [EU leaders](#) are prioritising simplification and regulatory restraint to foster competitiveness. As a result, the proposal will serve as a test of the EU's ability to protect consumers from harmful practices without stifling a sector that has become an important part of the digital economy.

## MAIN REFERENCES

[The impact of influencers on advertising and consumer protection in the Single Market](#), Committee on the Internal Market and Consumer Protection (IMCO), European Parliament, 2022.

## ENDNOTES

- <sup>1</sup> Various sources categorise influencers in groups according to the number of their followers. For example, the [IMCO study](#) categorises influencers in five groups: mega-influencers (more than one million followers); macro-influencers (between 500 000 and one million followers); medium influencers (between 40 000 and 500 000 followers); micro-influencers (between 10 000 and 40 000 followers); and nano-influencers (less than 10 000 followers).
- <sup>2</sup> When the products contain dangerous components.
- <sup>3</sup> In its version of 8 October 2025.
- <sup>4</sup> Italy's self-regulatory body overseeing ethical standards in advertising.
- <sup>5</sup> This section aims to provide a flavour of the debate and is not intended to be an exhaustive account of all different views.

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